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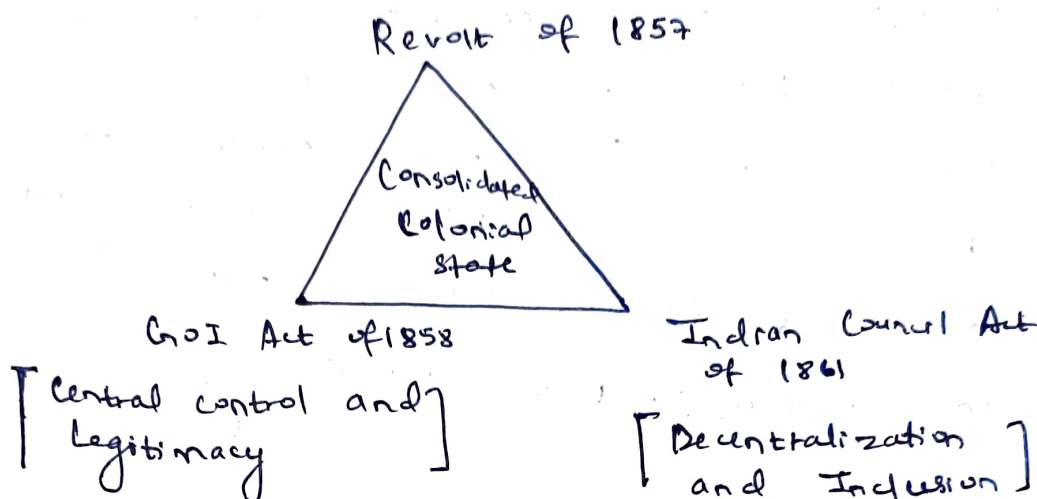
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Q- Discuss how the Government of India Acts of 1858 and 1861 reflect the British response to the revolt of 1857 - not just as a political crisis, but as an administrative reckoning.

Ans. The revolt of 1857 was a turning point in British colonial history. The British realised that revolt was not just a political crisis but a signal that their administrative machinery had failed. The Government of India Acts of 1858 and 1861 were not only intended to restore British authority but to rebuild the colonial system.

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① Imperial administration —

↳ The Act of 1858 abolished the East India Company and transferred Indian governance to the British crown.

↳ This marked a shift from private mercantile rule to a formal imperial State.

② Central Coordination —

↳ The Act of 1858 created a new office Secretary of State for India assisted by a Council. It

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introduced structured and supervised
governance reducing scope for
administrative lapses seen during
the revolt.

③ Restoring legitimacy —

↳ It brought an end to Doctrine
of Lapse giving protecting to princely
states

↳ It reflected an administrative
lesson preventing future discontent

④ Decentralisation —

↳ The Indian Council Act of 1861
restored legislative powers to Bombay
and Madras Presidencies and
allowed them to frame laws

↳ It was a response to the
over-centralisation making administration
more responsive.

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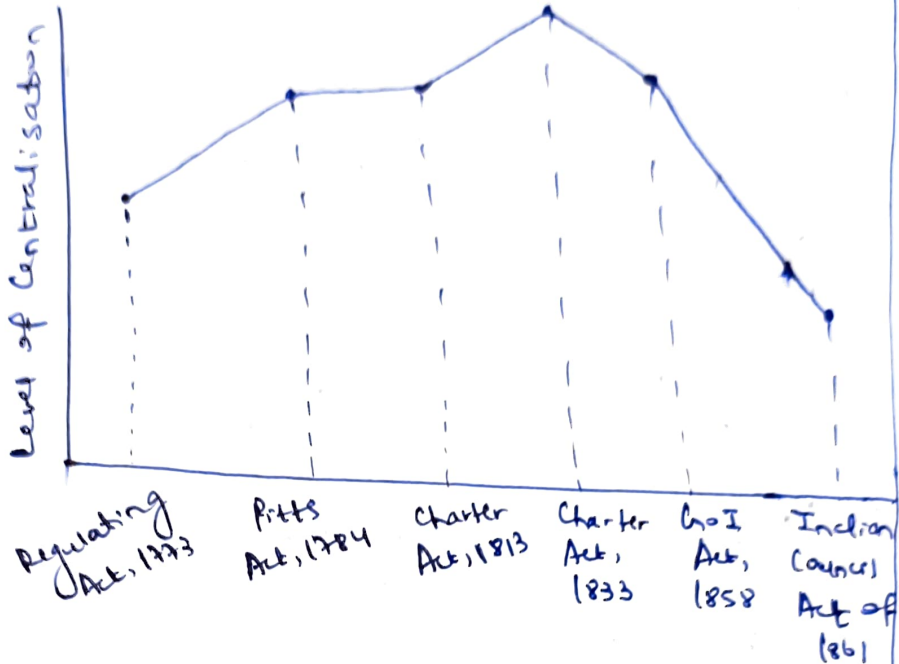


Fig: Trend of Administrative Centralisation to Decentralisation

⑤ Token Participation —

↳ The Act of 1861 introduced nomination of Indian members in the legislative councils. It was an administrative tactic to manage dissent through inclusion rather than exclusion.

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⑥ [Accountability] —

- ↳ The Act of 1861 introduced portfolio system which enable functional specialisation and accountability.
- ↳ It replaced arbitrary and overlapping authority of earlier period.

⑦ [Reforms in military] —

- ↳ The army was reorganised and ratio of British to Indian troops was increased. It was in response to military indiscipline and weak bureaucratic capacity.

The Acts of 1858 and 1861 were more than just tools to reassert British rule. They were a part of larger administrative reckoning.